2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Nathania Lopez

Grade / Grado 8th

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Valentin

School / Escuela Rachel Carson

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

Fatherhood is one of the most important jobs in the world. It's about being someone your family can always count on. My dad sets a really good example because he ' s someone who actually puts in the effort every day. He balances a lot between his job as well as taking care of us, and he does it by being hardworking, generous, and helpful. These are the main reasons why he ' s a great dad.

First of all, my dad is the hardest worker I know. He gets up early every morning and drives hours to get to his job, even when he ' s tired, to make sure we have everything we need. He never complains about being exhausted, and even after a long day, he still finds the energy to take care of things around the house. Seeing how much effort he puts into his work teaches me that you have to be dedicated if you want to provide for the people you love.

Another thing that makes my dad special is how generous he is. He doesn ' t just spend money on us, but he gives his time and energy to make sure we are happy. If I want to try a new sport or need something for school, he ' s the first one to say to agree and help out. He also helps out neighbors, friends and even strangers without expecting anything in return. He has a huge heart and always puts other people ' s needs before his own.

On top of being hardworking and generous, my dad is also the most helpful person I know. Whenever I'm struggling with a tough math problem or something breaks in my room, I know I can always go to him and he'll help me. He doesn't just do the work for me, though, he takes the time to explain how it works so I can learn how to do it myself next time. He is incredibly smart and is always willing to share that with everybody by helping out when he can.

In conclusion, my dad is a great role model because of his work ethic, his kindness, and his willingness to help. He shows me every day what it means to be a good person and a great father. I feel really lucky to have him in my life because he makes our family better just by being himself. He ' s more than just a parent, he ' s someone I truly look up to.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.